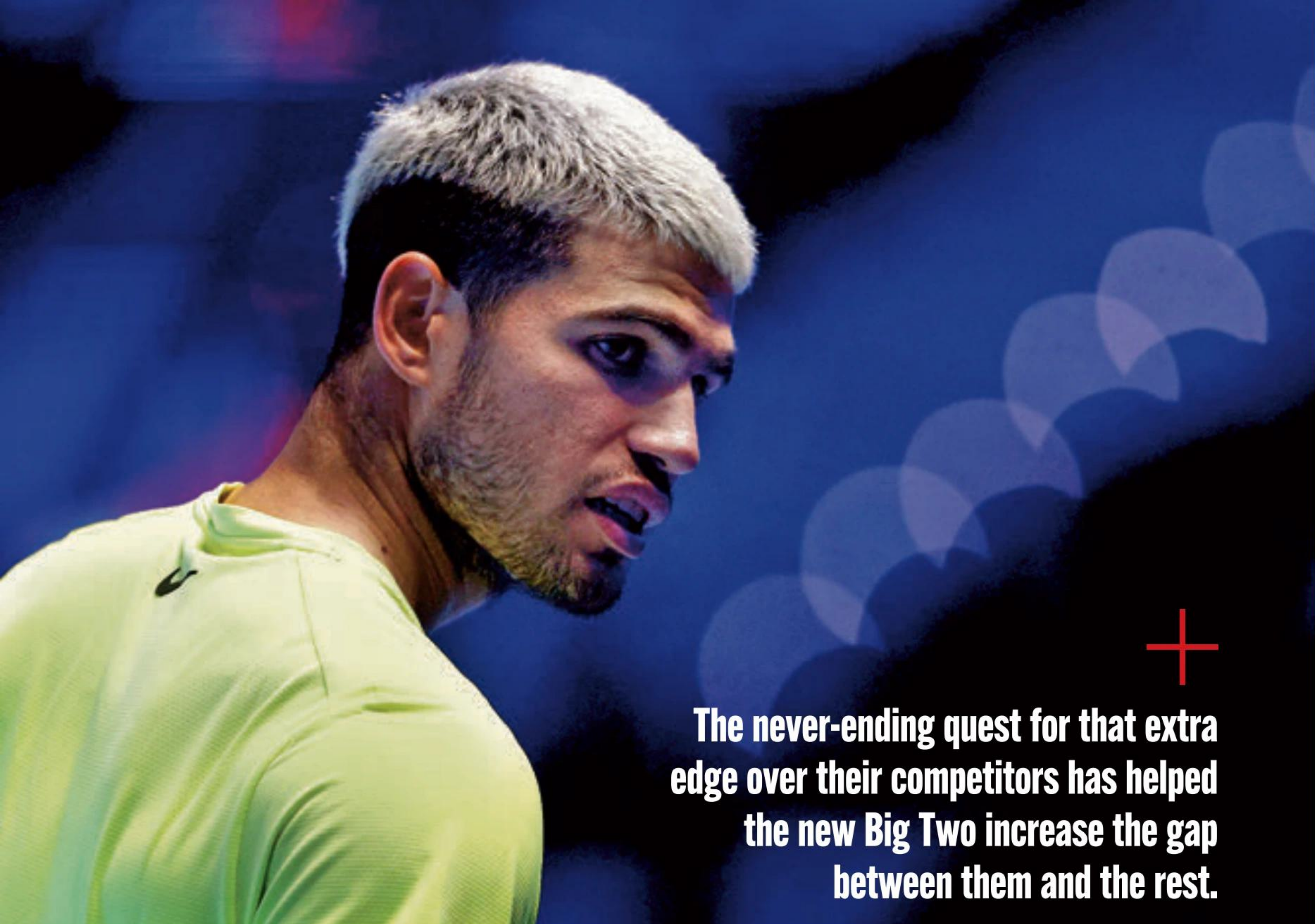




The never-ending quest for that extra edge over their competitors has helped the new Big Two increase the gap between them and the rest.

Technical evolution: After his Wimbledon final loss to Sinner this year, Alcaraz shortened his groundstroke backswings by six inches and added five grams to his racquet to increase power and add stability on serve returns. REUTERS

chant, and sing for their beloved folk hero. Alcaraz grinned when he mentioned that he hoped to have three or four fans rooting for him.

Following that disappointing four-set loss to Alcaraz at Flushing Meadows, Sinner acknowledged he was “too predictable.” Just as Alcaraz had upgraded his tactics after Sinner whipped him in the Wimbledon final — shortened his groundstroke backswings by six inches and added five grams to his racquet to increase power and add stability on serve returns — Sinner had to make major changes to improve.

“Sinner is shadow boxing against Alcaraz,” pointed out Courier on *Tennis Channel*, who noted that his own technique limitations prevented him from challenging superstar Pete Sampras 30 years ago.

“Sinner changed his serve. The toss is further to the left and less forward, and he lands closer to the

baseline. Now he serves more often towards the ‘T’ in the deuce court. It paid off as his first-serve percentage has shot up from 60 to 67,” Courier said after Sinner outclassed Alexander Zverev 6-4, 6-3 in a round-robin win. “He uses drop shots, he hits more angles and attacks less linearly [straight ahead]. He goes to the net more on groundstrokes and serves and volleys, usually when he has a 30-love or 40-love lead.”

It’s doubtful Sinner will copy a controversial training method called ischaemic preconditioning that Alcaraz has used since 2023. Far more extreme than the hyperbaric chamber that 24-time Major champion Novak Djokovic used, Alcaraz temporarily cuts off his own blood supply with occlusion bands or blood-flow restriction (BFR) bands to strengthen his muscles and increase his stamina.

The never-ending quest for that extra edge over their competitors has helped the new Big Two increase the gap between them and the rest. But their superior technique was most evident when Sinner stopped fast-rising No. 5 Ben Shelton 6-3, 7-6(3). “In the backcourt rallies, Sinner’s advantage is massive off both wings, especially when he hits it to Shelton’s backhand,” said Courier.

Big Ben, who blasts 140 mph lefty serves, also has stroke defects on the volley, which he chops down instead of punching forward, and on the forehand, which has an overly long backswing and is not grooved. Not surprisingly, Shelton has only two top-10 wins this year (against 10 losses) — over No. 4 Taylor Fritz and No. 8 Alex de Minaur at Toronto.

Similarly, Lorenzo Musetti, a splendid athlete with the best one-handed backhand in the world, was overpowered by defending